back a ways. British archaeologist Sir Alexander Cunningham recorded the event in 1865. Shobita Punja, a writer on Khajuraho, has claimed, though based on little evidence, that even a thousand years ago—in Khajuraho's prime when these temples were built—people celebrated Shivratri and hosted a divine wedding.

However, few would disagree that the most amazing and captivating aspect of these temples is their fine erotic art. Every modern visitor likely wonders: What does this art actually *mean*? What kind of people built this? Why did they depict sex so vividly on their temple walls, right next to their gods? Or as Devangana Desai, a noted scholar of the erotic temple sculpture of India, asked while pursuing her PhD in late 1960s Bombay: What explains 'the enigmatic presence of sex in the religious art of a culture that glorified austerity, penance and renunciation'?[1] These are also the questions that have brought me to Khajuraho. Their answers, as I have learnt, are neither as clear-cut nor as well-known—even among our scholarly literary elites—as one might imagine for such a major tourist spot and UNESCO World Heritage Site. I simply have to find out for myself.



Figure 1. Amorous couple, Lakshmana Temple